

World in Brief: French court blocks social-media ban; Luigi Mangione pleads guilty to federal charges



Photograph: Getty Images

A court in **France** blocked a bill that would prohibit under-15s from using [social media](#). In a setback for Emmanuel Macron, the president, France's Constitutional Council ruled that a ban would infringe on children's freedom of speech and communication. [Britain](#) and Germany are among the countries considering similar restrictions; Australia did so last year.

Luigi Mangione admitted to [fatally shooting Brian Thompson](#), the boss of UnitedHealthcare, America's biggest health insurer, in Manhattan in 2024. He pleaded guilty to two federal charges of stalking. Mr Mangione will be sentenced in December and faces life in prison. His lawyers are now seeking to dismiss a separate state murder charge in New York, for which a trial is scheduled next month.

Zambia's electoral commission resumed counting ballots in the country's [elections](#), after briefly suspending it because polling staff were attacked and marked ballots were stolen. A spokesperson said a security threat was "contained". Hakainde Hichilema, the incumbent president, has called for calm and patience; his main

challenger, Brian Mundubile, has claimed victory, apparently without solid evidence. The results are expected on Monday.

Yields on short-dated **American Treasuries** fell following weak **consumer-spending** data. Retail sales declined by 0.6% in July compared with a month earlier, softening the case for an interest-rate rise. Long-term bond yields barely budged. On Thursday America's Treasury sold \$25bn-worth of 30-year bonds with yields of up to 5.22%, the highest since 2001. Investors are concerned about America's \$40trn debt and high inflation.

Nigel Farage [won](#) a by-election in Clacton that he triggered by resigning as the town's MP. The leader of Reform UK, a populist right-wing party, said victory would show he had popular support against "the establishment". Critics said it was to distract from scrutiny over an undeclared £5m (\$6.8m) gift. The major parties boycotted the election. His main opponent, a comedy character called Count Binface, won 9,455 votes to Mr Farage's 22,239.

NATO fighter jets shot down a **drone** over Latvia, the country's defence ministry said. It blamed the incursion on "Russian electromagnetic warfare", but did not say which country the drone belonged to. **Europe** is struggling to protect its airspace. Earlier this month a Russian drone [almost succeeded](#) in blowing up a Ukrainian transport plane parked in Leipzig-Halle Airport in Germany.

A group of investors that includes **Jeff Bezos**, the founder of Amazon, agreed to buy a minority stake in **Liverpool Football Club**, said Fenway Sports Group, its majority owner. They will acquire a stake of roughly a third, according to reports. The deal could raise Liverpool's valuation to around \$7.5bn, making it one of the world's most expensive [football clubs](#).

Figure of the day: \$16bn, the annual sales that orexin medicines for sleep disorders could generate by 2035, according to Morgan

Stanley, a bank. [Read our story](#) about the new drugs regulating wakefulness.

The US in Brief: The aircraft-carrier shuffle



Photograph: Reuters

America is reportedly sending an **aircraft-carrier** to the Middle East to relieve the *USS Abraham Lincoln*, after reports emerged of supply shortages, water contamination and worsening crew morale. Some have reportedly attempted to jump overboard. Pete Hegseth, the war secretary, said conditions had been “completely misrepresented”. The vessel, which has been supporting operations against Iran with a crew of about 5,000 sailors, has not made a port call in more than 200 days. Democratic senators, including Richard Blumenthal and Ruben Gallego, have sounded the alarm.

The board of the **John F. Kennedy Centre** for the Performing Arts, in Washington, DC, reportedly voted to reattach Mr Trump’s name to the building—months after a judge ordered its removal on the grounds that only Congress had authority to alter the centre’s name. The updated signage would credit Mr Trump for renovations, in an attempt to reinsert his name without contravening the judge’s order. The board, which Mr Trump has filled with allies, made the decision soon after it voted to close parts of the venue for two years for building work.

The **White House** accused **China** of evading [American tariffs](#) by rerouting exports through more than 40 countries. It said other nations subject to high tariffs are doing something similar. The

Trump administration estimates that “the great transshipment scam” will cost the government up to \$26bn in annual tax revenue. It is developing an AI-powered “detective border” to catch tariff-dodgers.

A federal judge in Boston dismissed the Trump administration’s **antisemitism lawsuit** against **Harvard University**. The lawsuit alleged that the university allowed discriminatory behaviour during student protests against Israel’s war in Gaza. The judge said the incidents were “too isolated and episodic” to prove a violation of civil-rights law. The administration has repeatedly [bashed Harvard](#), which it sees as a hotbed of antisemitism and left-wing indoctrination.

Luigi Mangione is expected to plead guilty to federal charges of stalking related to the death of Brian Thompson, a health-insurance boss. The charges carry a maximum sentence of life in prison. He separately faces a murder charge in a New York state trial, due to begin in September. A federal plea would probably prompt his lawyers to seek a dismissal of the New York case under the state’s double jeopardy rule, which aims to prevent someone being tried for the same crime twice. State prosecutors are likely to argue their case differs considerably.

Flock Safety said it would make it mandatory for law enforcement teams using its AI-powered camera systems to switch on safeguards in its software. Several police officers have been accused of using the firm’s systems, which gather and record data on vehicles and number plates, to stalk women. The firm said the safeguards—which already exist but are currently optional—track use and suspend access when they detect suspicious behaviour.

Figure of the day: 35%, the proportion of registered voters in Iowa who are independents. A lot of them appear to be swinging left. [Our story examines](#) why Republican policies have alienated many Iowans.

A rain check for Europe's growth



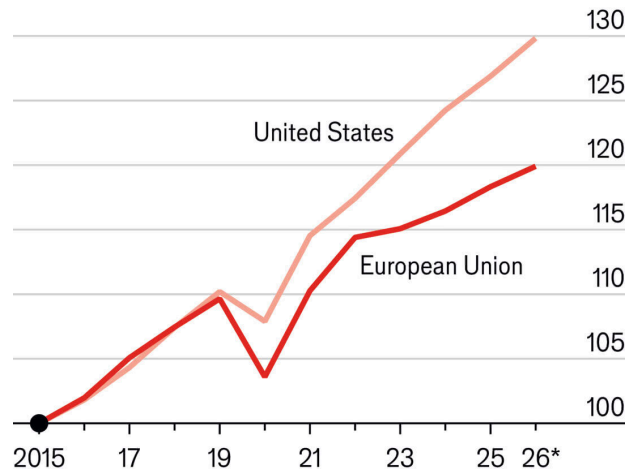
Photograph: Getty Images

The European Union published revised estimates of the bloc's second-quarter GDP on Friday alongside new employment data. The euro area grew by 0.4% in the three months to June, and the entire EU's economy expanded by 0.5%. The employment rate increased by a modest 0.1% in both the euro area and the EU.

Europe's recovery was already threatened by the war in Iran. Now the continent is suffering its fifth heatwave of the year. Triodos, a Dutch bank, has said that drought could wipe out much of the bloc's growth for the year. Poor harvests push up food prices; [drying rivers](#) disrupt shipping and power stations, which use the water for cooling. In France exceptional heat is expected to shave 1.4% off GDP this year, which could plunge the country into a recession. In the spring the European Commission had forecast annual growth of 0.9% for the euro zone and 1.1% for the EU. But that was before the rain stopped falling.

Running aground

GDP, 2015=100



Source: IMF

*Forecast

A twinkle of hope for Venezuelan democracy



Photograph: MIGUEL GUTIERREZ/EPA/Shutterstock

When American forces snatched Venezuela's dictator, Nicolás Maduro, in January, it was oil, not democracy, that seemed to be Donald Trump's priority. Yet [prospects for democracy](#) are improving. This week a first round of negotiations between Venezuela's regime and opposition figures ended with a modest agreement to begin a process of judicial reform, including of the Supreme Court.

Further talks may produce additional changes that could prepare the way for fair elections. [Expect intense negotiations](#) over who will sit on Venezuela's five-person electoral council and the Supreme Court. Negotiators will also discuss banned opposition politicians, guarantees for regime members who lose office and, on the margins, political prisoners. America has kept María Corina Machado, the main opposition leader, out of the talks, partly on the logic that if she is to run for president she should not be setting the rules. The next steps will be fiendishly difficult. American pressure on the regime will determine whether Venezuela has a good chance of returning to democracy.

Asics finds its stride



Photograph: Getty Images

In 1962 a pair of trainers caught the eye of Phil Knight, the future co-founder of Nike, while he was visiting Japan. He struck a deal with their maker, Kihachiro Onitsuka, to sell them in America. A decade later the pair fell out. After Mr Knight started Nike, Mr Kihachiro founded Asics. Today Nike is a global giant, but [is struggling](#) with falling sales as customers turn to more fashionable competitors. Asics, which reported second-quarter earnings on Friday, is one such.

The company keeps hitting [PBs](#). In the first half of 2026 operating profit rose by 49% year on year to \$757m. A [running](#) renaissance has boosted sales of its pricey trainers; recently it has outsold Nike and Adidas, a German rival, when it comes to pairs costing over \$90. Onitsuka Tiger, Asics' fashion label, is growing, too, helped by a weak yen and a [tourism boom in Japan](#). Across the industry, Asics is setting the pace.

A biopic with bite



Photograph: Seacia Pavao/A24

“I was—to be frank—a spoiled, miserable, narcissistic, self-destructive and thoughtless young lout, badly in need of a good ass-kicking,” wrote Anthony Bourdain in “Kitchen Confidential”, his memoir published in 2000. This confession opens “Tony”, a rollicking biopic of the late American chef’s formative years released in British cinemas on Friday (and in America on August 21st).

The film has plenty of bite. Dominic Sessa captures a teenage Bourdain’s swaggering yet sometimes self-conscious manner. And viewers experience the momentum of the chaotic kitchen where “the cooks *ruled*”, doing as much cocaine as cooking. The movie serves up plenty of actual bites, too: from lobster thermidor to clambake. “Tony” offers a small slice of Bourdain’s life and doesn’t mention his suicide in 2018. His former assistant reckons the chef would have objected to “the narrative’s sunny resolution”. After all, Bourdain saw that people, and kitchens, were fascinatingly messy.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which city is the site of the Truman Presidential Library?

Thursday: Which civil rights leader was baptised with the name of Michael, only to have his name changed by his father at the age of five?

*The aim of science is not to open
the door to infinite wisdom, but to
set some limit on infinite error.*

Bertolt Brecht